



WATCH OUT
The Bhavya Ramesh x NorBlack
NorWhite collab spotlights nazar
battus, fangs and ghunghroos **P2**

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Mehrunisha Shaukat
Ali, India's first female
bouncer, at Saket.
SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

The Women at the Door

From nightclubs to concerts, India's female bouncers are redefining a profession long dominated by men — and making public spaces more welcoming for women

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A couple of months ago, 22-year-old Sonika Kanwar was out with friends at Social, in South Delhi's swish Saket, when a group of men at a nearby table began leering in ways that made them uneasy. "Within 10 minutes, a woman bouncer walked up to the men's table and said something to them. They left soon after. We hadn't even called her; she just read the room," Sonika recalls.

When she went up to thank her, the response was brief and matter-of-fact. "She just said, 'It's my duty, ma'am'. But, I felt deeply indebted. She made me feel safe." It was only later, that Sonika realised who she had encountered: Mehrunisha Shaukat Ali, widely recognised as India's first woman bouncer, whose presence commands both authority and respect in a profession long dominated by men.

In a nightlife economy, where women are often left to negotiate discomfort on their own, such interventions underscore the growing role of female bouncers in India as first responders to unease.

In her career spanning over two decades, Mehrunisha, 40, has handled many such incidents. "I have tackled everything, from drunken women hurling abuse at me to sloshed men making inappropriate passes at women and the infamous name-droppers of Delhi's well-connected circles trying to enter clubs using social currency," she says.

Having worked across clubs, hospitals, political rallies and celebrity shows, Mehrunisha's passion for her profession is fuelled by a deeper desire to protect and serve. It stems from her childhood dream of joining the police or armed forces.

"My aspirations, like those of most girls from small towns, were caged in the confines of conservative social beliefs. At our

home in a small locality of Saharanpur, UP, my father, one of the custodians of this restrictive social system, did not support me. My mother did. And though I missed my chance to join the police or Indian armed forces, I found my way into security," she says.

She outlines the contrast between security guards and bouncers, a difference she learnt early on. When she first entered the profession, being labelled a "security guard" unsettled her. "My family moved to Delhi, in search of better opportunities after my father's business suffered a setback.



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

“We are not goons, and violence is not our first response to a difficult situation — it is the last resort. Our job is to defuse conflict, which can include physically restraining an attacker while the police are called”

MEHRUNISHA SHAUKAT ALI

That's when I began working as a bouncer. A well-built man dressed in black, who first caught my attention, introduced me to the profession. *Security guards haath jodte hai aur bouncers haath maraod dete hai* (security guards fold hands, while bouncers twist arms)," she says.

Yet, she is careful to define the limits of that force. "We are not goons, and violence is not our first response to a difficult situation — it is the last resort. Our job is to defuse conflict, which can include physically restraining an attacker while the police are called," she adds.

This is where security service providers step in. While these companies often use an umbrella term for all security personnel, comprising both guards and bouncers, the training for bouncers is distinct, with a specialised syllabus tailored to the demands of the role. Bouncers in India are regulated under the Private Security Agencies (Regulation) Act, 2005 (PSARA), which mandates that security agencies must be licensed and the security staff must undergo training and background checks.

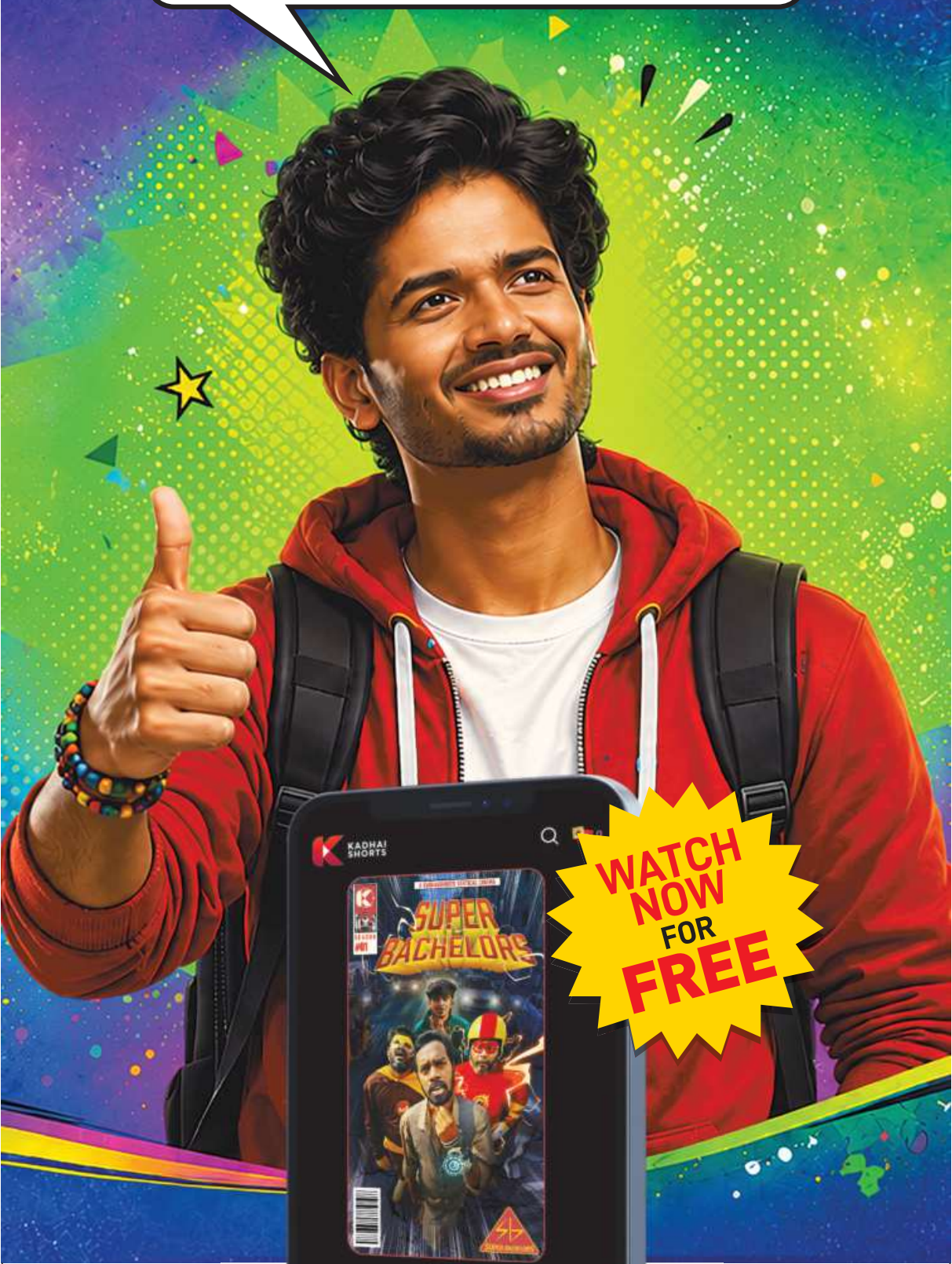
"We started hiring women bouncers around two years ago because women guests also had to be frisked for drugs, and it wouldn't be right for male staff to do that. But their role goes beyond frisking — they also step in when women patrons are too drunk to walk, need help getting to their car, or when fights break out between women," said Zahir Naina, head of operations, at Chennai-based bar Radio Room.

Anubhav Khiwani, founder of Delhi-and-Mumbai-based Denetim Services, explains, "Bouncers are not permitted to harm anyone; their role is to prioritise client safety at all times, and their conduct (body language and behaviour) must remain non-threatening. These principles form the core of their training."

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pick of the week



Coffee to kicks
Your morning coffee just got a second life. Teaming up with sustainable footwear label Thaely, Subko has launched a limited-edition Everyday Arabica sneaker, crafted using spent specialty coffee grounds, recycled plastic bags and recycled rubber. With 250 pairs available worldwide, the upcycled drop can be found at Subko in Mumbai's Mary Lodge, Dubai's Alserkal Avenue and online at subko.coffee. Priced ₹8,500 in US sizes 4 to 12.



Grand slam kulfi
Wimbledon's famed strawberries-and-cream tradition has taken a distinctly Delhi turn. In a playful collaboration with Kuremal's, the iconic dessert arrives as a limited-edition Strawberries & Cream Kulfi, bringing together British summer nostalgia and artisanal kulfi-making. Priced at ₹80, the special creation is available until July 12 at Kuremal's outlets in Bengali Market, Chandni Chowk, Connaught Place and Hauz Khas Market, Delhi.



A Singapore soir  e
A taste of Singapore lands in Chennai as Chef Sowmiya brings her Singai Penn pop-up to Chin Chin at The Residency. Till June 28, diners can savour Singapore's hawker-inspired favourites such as har cheong gai, marmite chicken, prawn laksa and black pepper soft shell crab, alongside comforting classics like chicken hor fun and kaya toast. Priced ₹2500 plus taxes. For reservation call 98415 55806



Grace in motion
Celebrate the beauty of Bharatanatyam at Varnajalam, a two-day showcase of rare varnams that have shaped India's classical dance legacy. Watch celebrated artistes including Padmashri Narthaki Nataraj, Swarnamalya Ganesh, Meenakshi Chitharanjan, Parshwanath Upadhye and more. On June 27 and 28, 5.30 pm onwards, at Asian College of Journalism, MS Subbulakshmi Arangam, Taramani. Tickets on kynhood.com



Where memories belong

Rediscover home at Landscapes of Belonging, where art meets memory and identity

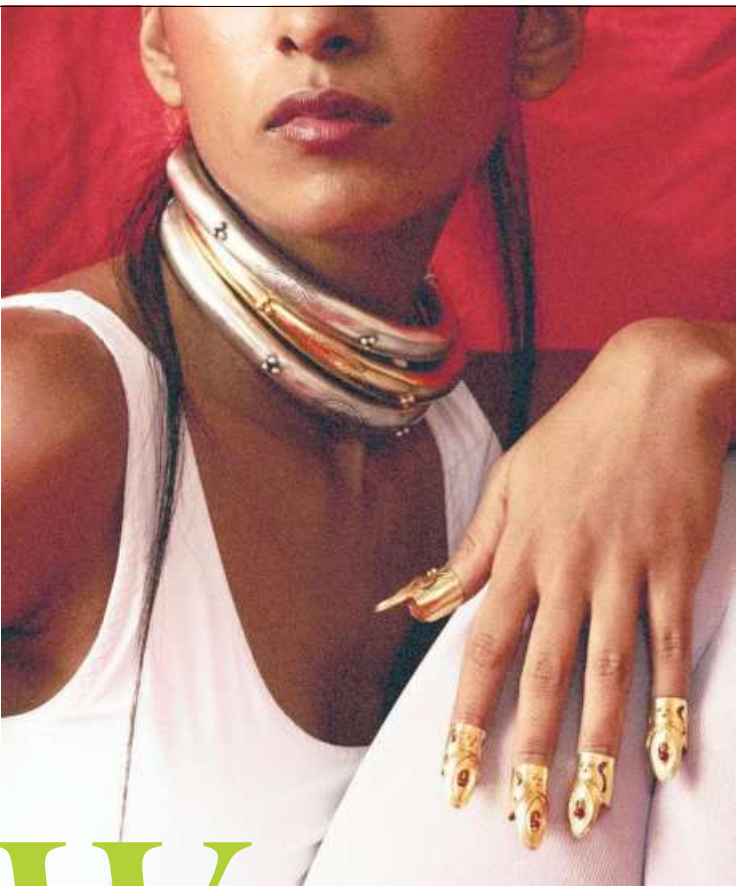
Priyamedha Dutta
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For some, home is more than just four walls; it is a place of refuge, an idea or even a person. Through Landscapes of Belonging, presented by Madras Art Weekend in collaboration with *The Hindu's* Made of Chennai initiative, artists explore the many meanings of home through identity, heritage and memory. Actor and filmmaker Suhasini Maniratnam's debut digital artworks are deeply rooted in Chennai, the city she calls home. Alongside depictions of the

Shore Temple and the Parthasarathy Temple, she speaks about how the Besant Nagar has shaped her artistic practice. "I think there are things that we see every day, but we just don't register them. I just want people to notice what is around them," she says. In this fast-paced world, artist P Saravanan invites viewers to pause and embrace the quiet of everyday life. His paintings are rich in luminous blues, warm ochres, and shades of red, with animals appearing in almost all his works, weaving together moments of companionship and coexistence. One painting depicts a man with a parrot

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There is a reason the most unsettling objects are often the ones meant to protect us. In parts of India, homes and shops display *nazar battus*: faces with bulging eyes, protruding tongues, and intimidating expressions meant to deflect the evil eye. They are rarely conventionally pretty, their exaggerated features often veering into the uncanny. Yet their purpose is deeply caring. They stand guard. That contradiction sits at the heart of STARE, the first collaboration between jewellery designer Bhavya Ramesh and fashion label NorBlack NorWhite, founded by artists Amrit Kumar and Mriga Kapadiya. Conceived as a collection of jewellery and accessories that protects the unwanted gaze rather than invites it, STARE is a reflection on life lived under scrutiny, both online and off. "We have long been champions of protecting your spirit. This felt like a very natural extension of this sentiment," says Mriga. "Every single woman has experienced the universal feeling of an unwanted gaze. This has amplified with our voyeuristic, super public culture where we don't know how deep that unwanted gaze can go." The brand has, over the years, built a visual language rooted in Indian textiles, crafts and everyday cultural practices, the idea of protection felt instinctive. Their work has consistently drawn from local symbols, textiles, and traditions, translating them into contemporary clothing and storytelling. Bhavya Ramesh's world is not far removed. The Mumbai-based, Bengaluru-born designer has become known for jewellery that feels more talismanic. Her pieces, often sculptural and symbol-laden, draw from mythology, memory and mysticism. Adornment, in her universe, is rarely decoration for decoration's sake. "My work has always existed



Wear the stare

NorBlack NorWhite and Bhavya Ramesh come together to turn protective charms into jewellery

in the space of symbolism first, and adornment after," says Bhavya. "I'm also a very superstitious person. I exist in this realm of myth, mystery and belief, and I think there are many things that exist beyond science and logic." **See no evil** The meeting point between the two brands became the *nazar battu*. While exploring ideas around protection, everyday objects and feminine power, the familiar protective charm outside Indian homes seemed to encapsulate everything they

wanted to express. Travelling through south India, the founders of NorBlack NorWhite had long been fascinated by the different regional interpretations of these protective symbols. They also recognised that talismans against the evil eye exist across cultures, each shaped by local mythology and belief. STARE translates that protective intent into objects worn on the body, conceived around a simple proposition: the body is home and adornment can become armour. The collection comprises 13 jewellery pieces, including

Pieces from the collection. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



earrings, rings, hair clips, anklets and rings, available in both silver and gold, alongside a vegan leather bag and a pair of ghunghroo socks. Symbols associated with protection have been reimagined through fangs, lemons, chillies, snakes, moons, eyes, tongues and even the ghunghroo, whose jingling sound is repurposed as another protective device. The motifs deliberately court discomfort. "Feminine beauty is often represented as soft, tender and nurturing," says Bhavya. "But I think we rarely see the other side of it – the chaos, rebellion, grit and fight that also exist within womanhood." Beauty, in STARE, is not designed to soothe, but unsettle, and perhaps even challenge the person doing the looking. "Being fierce is a huge part of the feminine experience," says Mriga. "One that often gets categorised as being 'crazy', which is just a low vibrational way of shutting down a transformative expression that can destruct the status quo." The collection's central face, with its unwavering gaze and almost intimidating presence, becomes a metaphor for womanhood itself. Fierce from the outside, deeply protective within. "With STARE, we wanted to hold both energies at once," says Mriga. "The collection is protective and caring at its core, but it does not express that protection quietly. It is sharp, dramatic, almost intimidating because sometimes protection has to look that way." Both brands describe the collaboration as inevitable. Building creative platforms led by women has meant navigating obstacles that eventually gave way to more supportive ways of working, STARE, they say, honours these cycles and finds beauty in discomfort. *The collection will be available online through both brands, with select retail availability in Mumbai and Delhi. Prices range from ₹2,500 to ₹39,900*

(Clockwise from left) Artworks by artists NS Manoharan and P Saravanan, and a visitor viewing the artwork. SR RAGHUNATHAN



picking tarot cards, while others capture a Jallikattu scene with men engaging with bulls and in another a little girl tenderly cradling her cat. Artist Neena Makhija's works reflect on the inner lives of women within shared spaces, how companionship can coexist with solitude, and how silence can speak of endurance, reflection, and subtle resistance. With her use of bright colours, women are seen in their spaces surrounded by mundane everyday tasks. "These works explore the fragile architecture of human relationships built through gestures, memory, silence, care, and absence. The figures occupy shared spaces yet carry private emotional worlds, revealing the tension between connection and isolation in contemporary life," says Neena. The exhibition also brings together emerging and



established artists, offering a diverse showcase of painting, photography, mixed media, ceramics and sculpture. For Chennai-born and raised artist Monika Umapathy, her ceramic works are deeply rooted in the city's landscapes. "The ceramic surface adds a physical and tactile dimension to the painted image, allowing me to preserve everyday observations in a material form," says Monika. **Quiet belonging** For artist and journalist Narayan Lakshman, home is found in

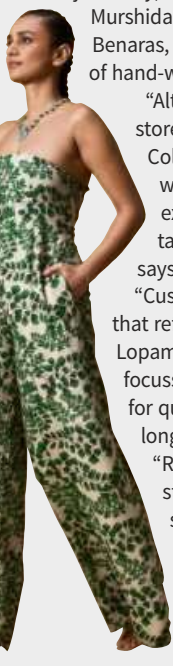
Chennai's beaches, the gentle morning light and the warmth of its people. Inspired by Zen Buddhism, his work evokes, in his words, "a sense of quiet belonging and an inner landscape as much as an exterior landscape, where everything is ephemeral and passing, yet everything beckons to you, holds you and embraces you. That sense of warmth, acceptance and the fortifying of one's own identity is what I hope this artwork." Also on view are the works of late artist T Athiveerapandian, offering visitors a glimpse into his enduring artistic legacy. Deeply inspired by nature, his landscapes were shaped as much by memory as by observation, with mountains, trees and lush greenery recurring throughout his work. Recalling his artistic vision, his wife, Susan Athi says, "He didn't just paint what he saw. Even a single tree held 10 or 15 shades of green for him, and those nuances found their way onto his canvas." In artist NS Manoharan's paintings, one can see the spirit of South India and the rich cultural heritage of the Thanjavur region. Having grown up in Kumbakonam, surrounded by villages, temples, ponds and fertile landscapes, he draws deeply from the memories of his childhood. His works celebrate a way of life that is slowly disappearing. "Through my paintings, I hope to preserve these disappearing memories and pass them on to future generations," he says. Together, the works on display reveal that home is not a singular place but a collection of memories, landscapes, relationships and lived experiences. Through diverse artistic voices and mediums, it invites visitors to pause, reflect and rediscover the familiar spaces that we inhabit around us. *Prices start at ₹2,500 onwards. Landscapes of Belonging is on at Lalit Kala Akademy till June 30. Entry is free.*

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Weaving Asia together

Textiles from India, especially Bengal, have played a huge role in Lopamudra starting her new venture, AltaRasa, a multi-label boutique and website that features creations by South Asian and South East Asian designers. "I felt that as a consumer there was a longing to discover Indian designs that are more than just occasion wear. When we think of fashion, it is Euro-centric or inspired by the US. A shift is happening now and that makes me happy," she says. AltaRasa has upcoming designers and established ones such as Maryalle, Lily Jean, and Stella Rissa from Indonesia. There are labels from Sri Lanka including Sonali Dharmawardena, MAUS, Arc En Ciel, and Anuk. The mix is eclectic with Indian designers bringing in heritage wear. There are collections by Payal Pratap, Aakaro, Re ceremonial, Namza Ladakh, Weaver's Studio, Surana Jewellers, Jaipur (fine jewellery), B Sirkar Johuree (heritage gold Bengal jewellery). There are representations from Murshidabad, Phulia (West Bengal), Benaras, Guwahati, and Assam in the form of hand-woven saris. "AltaRasa has a hybrid format: the store in Delhi's upscale Defence Colony will ensure that someone who walks in gets an immersive experience. While e-commerce takes us beyond geography," she says. "Customers want to wear something that reflects who they are," says Lopamudra, adding that her brand is focussed on a clientele that is looking for quiet luxury, cultural legitimacy and long-lasting wardrobe collectibles. "Repeating clothes is cool," she states, driving home the point that skilfully crafted garments need to be preserved and worn often. *Prices start at ₹25,000.*





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Where the Sky Breaks

Armed with weather models, radar imagery and cameras, the Kolkata Cloud Chasers pursue Bengal's most dramatic storms in search of photographs and the thrill of chasing lightning

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“I think that was Remal, no?”
“No, no. That was Bulbul.”
“But Fani was something else entirely.”
“And you’ve forgotten Mocha.”
The names move around the room, there is disagreement over details, affectionate correction, a collective remembering usually reserved for close friends.
Except these are not people. They are cyclones: Remal, Amphan, Bulbul, Fani, Mocha.
Across Bengal, they are remembered as disasters. But for the Kolkata Cloud Chasers they are remembered as encounters.
For the eight members of Kolkata Cloud Chasers, an extreme weather photography group, their lives are punctuated by cyclones, squall lines, thunderstorms and *kalbaisakhis* (summer tempest). They remember

where they stood when the horizon darkened, where they lost a signal, where lightning struck nearby, where a forecast proved spectacularly wrong.
For 12 years, they have spent weekends pursuing the very phenomena most people instinctively avoid.
A storm can weaken without warning, split into two systems, disappear entirely or arrive with a force beyond prediction.
That uncertainty is precisely what keeps them coming back. The members first met through the Kolkata Photographer’s Club, a community of roughly 2,500 photography enthusiasts on Orkut in 2009. What united them all was a fascination with weather and the desire to photograph it. On March 24, 2014, a WhatsApp group was formed and Kolkata Cloud Chasers was born.
An eclectic team
The group comes from remarkably different professional backgrounds.

Navigator and Nikon Grand Prix winner Debarshi Duttagupta works in the pharmaceutical industry. Suman Kumar Ghosh is an engineer and the team’s wind-data specialist. Chirasree Chakraborty, who runs a publication business, serves as one of the primary storm trackers. Joyjeet Mukherjee, a debt recovery expert, specialises in lightning photography. Krishnendu Chakraborty works in marketing, Indranil Kar is trek organiser and high altitude rescuer while Diganta Gogoi is a professional photographer. Abhishek Saigal runs a business and is known within the team for photographing lightning.
“We all have different roles,” says Debarshi. “Chirasree and Suman study wind data, trajectories and weather models. Joyjeet and I work as navigators. Diganta and Krishnendu track the storm. We also have spotters who locate storm cells from a distance because drivers cannot do that while driving.”



A tablet mounted inside the vehicle acts as a mobile command centre.
Every member contributes a different skill set, and reaching a storm often depends on all of them working in concert.
Inside the storm hunt
Storm chasing begins days before anyone gets into a car. The team constantly monitors weather models, IMD reports and applications such as Windy and WeatherBug. During the pre-monsoon season, they pay particular attention to conditions developing over Jharkhand’s Chhotanagpur Plateau near Ranchi,

where many *kalbaisakhis* (summer tempests) originate.
Routes are planned using weather forecasts, traffic conditions, travel time and expected storm movement. Yet even meticulous preparation offers no guarantees.
Speaking of cameras that capture the storms, Chirasree points out that she, Diganta, Abhishek and Joyjeet use a Nikon full frame DSLR. Debarshi has a Sony Mirrorless and Krishnendu uses a GoPro and a Fuji mirrorless. “Our success rate is only around 20 to 22%. A storm may break apart, disappear entirely or suddenly change direction,” says Debarshi.
When a chase succeeds, the team attempts to position itself parallel to the storm system, allowing members to photograph it while simultaneously recording meteorological observations and wind data.

Racing against the weather
“The data we receive is already at least ten minutes old,” says Chirasree.
That delay means storm chasers are effectively pursuing an atmosphere that has already changed by the time they see it on their screens.
A cloud formation that appears insignificant on radar may already be rapidly intensifying in reality.

(Clockwise from left) The sky darkens before a localised storm; thunder strikes Kolkata; orange lit skies preceding a bout of thunder; before the onset of cyclone Remal; lightning strikes a village in Bengal.
KRISHNENDU CHAKRABORTY, ABHISHEK SAIGAL, SUMAN KUMAR GHOSH, CHIRASREE CHAKRABORTY, DEBARSHI DUTTAGUPTA
Because of this lag, navigation becomes critical. “We work on probabilities. The navigator’s role is to estimate where the storm will be, not where it was,” Chirasree explains.
She adds, “This challenge becomes acute with thunderstorms and pre-monsoon thundershowers. Cyclonic systems can often be tracked ten days before formation. Local storms offer far less warning.”
When a chase fails, the team has developed a ritual of its own. “We stop somewhere, eat good food and come back,” chuckles Debarshi.
The atmosphere remains serious, but the group deliberately keeps its spirits light. “At the end of the day, we are photographers.”

Safety before spectacle
Before anyone steps out of a vehicle, the team identifies evacuation routes. Cars are parked facing the direction of departure. Keys remain in the ignition and one team member remains solely responsible for monitoring lightning activity .
The reason? Chirasree explains, with a glint in her eye, “In those moments you go into a trance. The awe of Nature can make you forget that you may need to run.”
Chirasree has received electric shocks through the tripod of her camera and Abhishek Saigal was struck by lightning and had temporarily lost sensation below his waist.
“Even after taking precautions, the possibility of getting struck by lightning remains,” says Debarshi.
“The clouds are rumbling, the thunder is cracking, and you realise how tiny you are in comparison. That feeling is priceless,” says Chirasree.

Fabian Rodrigues

Bengaluru-based Sukanth Rallapati and Vaibhav Dalal have been together for 14 years. They own a piece of land, run a household, and have built a family. When they bought that land as an investment a few years ago, both their names were added to the title once the transaction closed. However, there was no way to record what they were to one another. “We couldn’t say we were each other’s spouse or partner in any legally meaningful sense,” says Sukanth, 48. That’s a reality queer couples continue to navigate.”
On October 17, 2023, the Supreme Court declined to grant same-sex couples the right to marry, holding in a 3-2 verdict in *Supriyo v. Union of India* that the question belonged to Parliament. Almost three years on, Parliament has not acted. There is no marriage, no civil union, and no registered partnership.
There was, briefly, the appearance of movement. On August 28 2024, the Finance Ministry clarified that queer couples face no restrictions in opening a joint bank account or naming a partner as nominee; the Reserve Bank of India had told scheduled commercial banks the same a week earlier. Read carefully, the advisory created nothing. It clarified that no bar had ever existed. What stopped couples was rarely the rulebook. It was the counter, where two unrelated men or women asking to bank together have often been met with questions about a relationship that, without marriage, cannot be proved on paper. “More than the banks, it’s the regulatory specifications of each bank for opening accounts



Off the record

Same-sex couples in India can now share a bank account and name each other as nominees. But it gets complicated, with the law withholding everything that happens after death

that are the problem,” says a former banking professional on condition of anonymity.
Many banks, the observation goes, will raise questions when two unrelated men or women try to open a joint account together, querying a relationship status that, in the absence of legal marriage, cannot be substantiated on paper, even when both customers’ KYC documents are flawless.
Change on the ground
Axis Bank launched its

#ComeAsYouAre charter on September 6, 2021, three years ahead of the advisory, enabling joint accounts and partner nominations regardless of gender or marital status, and introducing the gender-neutral honorific ‘Mx.’
“The conversation was never ‘should we do this?’ It was ‘how do we do this right?’” says Shruthi Bopaiah, executive vice president and head of Sparsh (Customer Obsession) at Axis Bank. Nothing in the framework had ever barred a joint account or the nomination of

Representative images GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK
a non-spouse, she points out; the bank simply chose to say so, and build for it, before being told it could. The bank’s internal Pride network now runs over a thousand strong, and it holds more than 7,000 accounts for transgender and gender-diverse customers. In one town outside the metros, she says, a customer opened a joint account with their partner and chose the ‘Mx’ honorific at the counter, the branch completing the process “as a matter of routine rather than exception.” Where complaints surface, she adds, the question the bank asks itself is not whether to step back but how to do better.
Notably, Axis does not count its same-sex couples. “We would rather enable with dignity than reduce identities to data,” Shruthi says.
The ceiling no bank can raise
Sumir Nagar, who spent three decades building banking operations across North America, Europe, the Middle East and Asia-Pacific, explains why.

“The conversation was always about audit trails, KYC, and regulatory exposure. Never about the shape of a customer’s family. The family they imagined while building the form was the only family the form could see,” he says.
Under Indian law, a nominee is not an heir. In *Sarbaty Devi v. Usha Devi* (1984), reaffirmed in *Shakti Yezdani* (2023), the Supreme Court held that a nominee receives money only as a trustee for the legal heirs. For a queer person, that design can be devastating. “A queer person can name their partner as a nominee, feel protected, and then, after death, the partner stands as a legal custodian who may be required to hand everything over to estranged parents. That isn’t a loophole, but the design,” Sumir says.
Shruthi concedes that succession and insurance are “still being worked through, shaped as much by law as by policy.”
Place of privilege
The cleaner experiences, Sumir says, come from private banks and wealth desks. “It isn’t only about sexuality. It’s about privilege. A

couple with a private banker and a good estate lawyer can engineer around almost every gap. A couple at a crowded branch with a standard savings account cannot,” he adds.
Radhika Piramal, former managing director of VIP Industries and co-founder of Pride Fund India, India’s first dedicated LGBTQIA+ philanthropy fund, says she has never even attempted to open a joint account in India. She is precise about what marriage withholds. “It is also a contract with the state. That contract gives certain entitlements: a joint bank account, sharing property, automatic inheritance to the spouse, next-of-kin medical rights,” she says.
A registered will overrides any nomination. A will, a power of attorney, jointly held assets, beneficial nomination on insurance where allowed: none of it requires Parliament, only foresight. Sukanth and Vaibhav are now drafting exactly this. “We’re trying to make sure we don’t leave each other in limbo,” he says.
Until succession law catches up, the most radical financial act a queer couple can perform is a profoundly boring one. Sumir reduces it to three lines: Write the will, register it, but don’t trust the form.



Note: Under Section 45ZA of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949, the nominee on a bank deposit receives the funds on the account holder’s death and the bank is discharged on paying them. This does not make the nominee the owner.



The Women at the Door

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Denetim, he says, provides security staff to several businesses, including sports-retail store Decathlon, publishing house Penguin Books and luxury vehicle brand Jaguar. “The demand for female bouncers began to pick up around 2016, alongside the rise of luxury events and concerts, particularly for frisking women. We had set up our company in 2014. From there, demand expanded from clubs and bars to smaller private parties at farmhouses, and even court premises during divorce proceedings,” adds Anubhav. While Anubhav’s company started with just three to four female bouncers a decade ago, the numbers have increased. “We now have 10-15 female bouncers who keep working with us, off and on,” he says. Bouncers can be employed full-time with a company, engaged on customised contracts, or work as freelancers. Pushpa, who has

been on Denetim Services’s payroll for the past six years, is stationed at Decathlon, where she works eight-hour shifts and monitors shrinkage (inventory loss). “One has to stay constantly alert. It’s taxing, both mentally and physically,” she says. “For a regular shift, I earn around ₹25,000 a month. But at events, where we’re paid by the hour, I can make more.” She adds that logistics vary. “There’s no transport provided for day shifts, but night shifts usually include it. At events, sometimes the client covers travel; other times, the company shares the cost. Food is generally taken care of.” What Pushpa now assumes as a norm – the food, transport and even eight-hour shifts – did not come that easy for Mehrunnisha. Just three years into her career, she was already wrestling the petty biases meted out to female bouncers. “I still remember an event in 2006 where women bouncers were not even given water, while the men were served chicken korma. I refused to eat in protest. When the company head came to know

about it, he stepped in and ensured we were given food and water,” she says. “We would clock a gruelling 13-hour shift for a mere ₹200-₹300 and travel expenses too came from our own pockets. As for training, I would run or book a session at a small gym whenever I could afford it,” she adds.

Female bouncers check the IDs and bags of guests at Radio Room in Chennai. JOHAN SATHYADAS

Since 2020, Mehrunnisha has been running a security service company that she has now renamed from Mardani Bouncer & Dolphin Security to India First Lady Bouncer Security. She continues to work at Social, earning ₹22,000 a month, while also freelancing at events across North India. “I earn enough, but money is not my only motivation,” she says. “What truly matters is when women come up to thank me for helping them get home safely.” That sentiment, she adds, has found a quiet echo in Sonika’s experience. “She is now a regular at Social,” Mehrunnisha says. “She often messages me before coming and asks, ‘*Didi, aap hogi na wahan?*’ That trust of someone feeling safer just knowing you’re there is priceless.” She hopes to encourage more women to take up the profession, and it looks like she is having an impact already. “I have about 2,000 CVs sitting on my table,” she says, adding “I want to create opportunities for all of them.”



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Malayalam

Everyone delivers their best



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A certain expectation of a pleasant opening scene builds when the camera pans over a kid’s crayon drawings in the initial moments of Chidambaran’s *Balan*, until we realise that the drawings are on the walls of a prison cell, where the boy is lodged with his mother. That intriguing sequence sets the tone for the film.

The wall drawings provide a sanitised version of the mother and son’s traumatic past, with the film expanding our understanding of their background as the narrative progresses. Another version of their story comes in the form of a bedtime horror story, narrated to a grandmother. The mother (Farzana Palathingal) and son (Adisheshan KR and Mohammed Sinan) remain unnamed in the movie, for they live many lives under different identities in a bid to escape their past.

One of the marvellous things about *Balan* is how well it depicts the passage of time, like the initial montage of them shifting from one place to another, with different identities. It immediately gives us a feel of the perilousness of their existence and makes us fear for them every time the past is about to catch up. It is with the same delicate touch that the film later pulls us along when the narrative suddenly advances by several years.

In perhaps his best writing effort yet, Jithu Madhavan (*Aavesham*) makes us wonder about the psychological effects of witnessing what the boy does, without overtly stating it. We see it in the boy’s intense, deep-set eyes and in his little, borderline criminal tendencies during crises. The film’s gaze is never judgmental, but one of understanding. Clever writing choices pop up often in the narrative, such as the way it casually conveys the problematic background of a policeman. Only at the fag end of the film, when a character is heartlessly made collateral damage to fulfil the film’s objective, does *Balan* slip a little.

Each of the characters is well-etched, with all the performers – Farzana, Adisheshan, Zinan, Dolly June, Beena Antony, Jean Paul Lal – elevating it. Tovino Thomas, in a shorter role, delivers one of the best acts of his career. Sushin’s moody background score teases out the apt emotions in every scene.

With his supremely crafted third film after *Jan-e-Man* and *Manjummel Boys*, Chidambaram yet again proves his mastery over telling a story without missing a beat and by not treading the same paths that proved successful for him. One leaves the theatre with so much to unpack and ruminate, wondering what life has in store for these characters. In an era where most films now end with a forced sequel possibility, *Balan*’s definitive ending opens up a thousand possibilities in our minds.

Balan is currently running in theatres

Balan

Director: Chidambaram

Cast: Farzana Palathingal, Adhisheshan K.R., Muhammed Zinan, Dolly June, Tovino Thomas, Jean Paul Lal, Girish A.D., Anand Ekarshi

Storyline: A mother and son treads uncommon paths to escape from their traumatic past



An entertaining action drama

Samantha convincingly embraces a mass-action avatar in Nandini Reddy’s family drama, but underwritten twists keep the film from realising its full potential

Telugu

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At the end of *Maa Inti Bongaaram* (MIB), I kept thinking about what it could have been had the team gone all out with its blend of action entertainer and family drama. Telugu cinema rarely presents a sari-clad female protagonist who can deliver punches powerful enough to send shivers down the spines of thugs. That role belongs to actor-producer Samantha, who once again makes her action sequences convincing. The audience cheers during the high moments; that kind of stardom is earned over time.

Samantha’s third outing with director Nandini Reddy, co-produced by Raj Nidimoru, has plenty going for it. Parts of the film are genuinely enjoyable, blending humour, subtle social commentary and action. It remains immensely watchable but falls well short of being a standout.

The chinks in the armour lie in the writing. Raj Nidimoru, Vasanth Maringanti and Sita Menon, who lead the writing team, rework a mass-action template usually reserved for male stars. There are echoes of Rajinikanth’s *Baashha* – a framework overused in Tamil and Telugu cinema – with shades of *A History of Violence* and Vijay’s *Leo*. This is hardly a spoiler since the film’s promos have already laid out the broad contours of the story. Place a female protagonist, who yearns for domestic bliss even as her

Maa Inti Bongaaram

Director: Nandini Reddy

Cast: Samantha Ruth Prabhu, Gulshan Devaiah, Diganth

Storyline: A woman has to battle demons from the past that threaten to shatter her dream of being part of a happy family.



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violent past threatens to expose her, at the centre of this template and you have the makings of a winner.

Samantha is introduced as Swarna, another name for gold and a nod to the film’s title. The colours of her saris evoke turmeric and vermilion, symbols of auspiciousness, in her introductory scene as she worries whether her husband’s family will accept her. These early passages unfold with ease.

The large joint family seen here is reminiscent of several stereotypical mainstream Telugu films. Women and children clad in finery inhabit a large, tastefully done up home. The men go to work and women are content cooking up lavish meals and performing pujas. When Swarna, who can neither cook nor perform pujas to perfection, wonders whether she will fit in, the film comments on the expectations women are expected to live up to. Though the story is set in the 1980s, many women may still recognise these tropes, in varying degrees.

Swarna’s shortcuts to turn the tables in her favour are narrated through amusing moments, even if the household is populated by familiar archetypes. The subplot involving Swarna and her childhood friend Kiranmayee (Manjusha) is a hoot, as is her run-in with Anasuya (Sree Mukhi), the embodiment of the ideal daughter-in-law.

Through these portions, the film gradually builds anticipation around Swarna’s past. A car chase and a brief combat sequence at dawn act as teasers for what is to come.

The reveal, however, is where the film falters. In stories such as these, the payoff has to justify the carefully built

suspense. The manner in which Swarna’s past unfolds takes the wind out of the proceedings. Had this stretch been written with greater ingenuity, it could have delivered the rousing moment that fully justifies the presence of a mass-action heroine.

For the audience to completely invest in Swarna’s desire to win over her family, her relationship with her husband (Diganth) needed more depth. In contrast, Karna’s (Gulshan Devaiah) devious and controlling arc is better developed, even if it sidesteps the socio-political implications of his clan.

The film raises pertinent questions. What does it take for a woman manipulated in the past to unapologetically reclaim her voice? Can a woman who does not fit societal archetypes retain her individuality and still win over her family? These questions play out against the backdrop of a family under threat and Samantha getting to embrace her action-star persona. The performances, particularly those by the women, are among the film’s strengths.

It is a delight to watch Samantha own the action sequences, making them look effortless. In contrast, when she attempts to be the perfect daughter-in-law, it almost feels like role play, in keeping with the narrative’s demands.

Had the talented team of *Maa Inti Bongaaram* pushed the film’s possibilities with a smarter plot and a willingness to take greater risks, it could have become one of the rare female-led action dramas to leave a lasting mark. As it stands, it remains a watchable and enjoyable film.

Maa Inti Bongaaram is currently running in theatres

A flavourless concoction

Hindi

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Fourteen years after Deepika Padukone danced barefoot on our heartstrings as the chaotic, unforgettable Veronica, Homi Adajania returns to the bar with *Cocktail 2* but ends up serving a lukewarm mocktail of ideas and aesthetics.

The narrative playground shifts from the rainy, moody streets of London to the sun-drenched, high-fashion cliffs of Sicily. Kunal (Shahid Kapoor) and Diya (Rashmika Mandanna), a live-in couple whose decade-long bond has survived a long-distance relationship and COVID-19, hit a gorgeous obstacle in the form of Ally (Kriti Sanon) during a vacation in Italy. Trying to separate habit from commitment, and responsibility from burden, Diya decides to test Kunal’s loyalty by asking Ally to seduce him.

The narrative twist here is that the



women are the ones driving the confusion, and the boy gets into the mess with blinkers on. Diya’s deep-seated overthinking, spurred by a joke and Ally’s performative rebellion, fractures the relationship. However, after the initial burst of energy, the romantic comedy suffers from an identity crisis.

The concoction lacks the intoxicating emotional depth of the original and the sharp, unapologetic punch of a Ranjan comedy. Over the years, Adajania has built his

reputation by giving complex, unconventional urban women a genuine voice and a judgment-free space. While Ranjan famously views modern romance through a deeply cynical, male-centric lens, where women often function as calculated puppet masters. Together, they create a mashup in which the female voice is muffled, and the boy remains cute and blemish-free.

Moreover, Sicily’s artsy surface feels like a travel influencer’s Instagram reels, and beneath it lies a

manufactured plot structure in which the loyalty-test hook feels utterly artificial. In terms of idea, it belongs to a fast-paced, cynical comedy rather than to a soulful, relationship drama between flawed, urbane characters, which Adajania excels in.

In the original, the lines were sharply drawn by the clothes. Diana Penty wore traditional kurtas to signal purity and commitment, while Deepika wore short skirts to signal rebellion and emotional instability. Here, the makers seem to have evolved past this cliché; they ditch the obvious wardrobe visual cues. Rashmika is styled in chic and contemporary clothing, competing with Shahid and Kriti in the cleavage competition.

However, it turns out that this evolution is strictly costume-deep. Beneath the stylish wardrobe, which works like an advert for the upcoming wedding/honeymoon collection, the film forces her back into the same mould of a suffocating, insecure, and traditional woman. Moreover, Rashmika’s Hindi diction shatters the illusion of her character. Her eyes are expressive, but every

time she raises the pitch, the high-society world that Adajania effortlessly builds falls apart.

Kriti’s performance makes you realise what Deepika brought to the franchise when she stood under the strobe lights of a London nightclub and looked into the camera. She went on to give voice to a generation’s loneliness when Kavita Seth sang ‘*Main hoon hi nahin is duniya ki*’ for her. Veronica belonged to a rare breed of modern tragic

heroines – unapologetically messy, fiercely loyal, and deeply broken. Kriti possesses Deepika’s physicality, but her performance as Ally lacks the erratic, magnetic storm that made Veronica unforgettable

Shahid faces no friction stepping into Saif Ali Khan’s effortlessly charming shoes, retreating to his chocolate boy persona that still works. He brings a warm, reliable stability to a character who actually *wants* to anchor down.

In a pivotal scene, Kunal tries to explain true love by comparing it to an old, messy cupboard. He argues that even though it looks chaotic from the outside, you still know exactly where every single item is hidden. It is a warm, poetic idea. But the tragedy of *Cocktail 2* is that it treats its audience exactly the same way. It is a messy cupboard of a movie, but instead of feeling comforting, it just feels exhaustingly predictable. There is nothing much to look at inside!

Cocktail 2 is currently running in theatres.

Toy Story 5

Director: Andrew Stanton

Cast: Joan Cusack, Greta Lee, Tom Hanks, Tim Allen, Conan O'Brien

Synopsis: Jessie and friends take concerted efforts to save an eight-year-old Bonnie from getting hooked to Lilypad, a frog shaped tablet.



Woody and Buzz's return

English

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In its opening minutes, Toy Story 5 holds a strange anthropological sway as a swanky group of new age Buzz Lightyears get out of their packaging like early humans gaining consciousness. They start a fire at night in the forest and are struck by the glow of a star in the sky. Their first words, “star command”,

gives them a direction to reach home beyond the galaxy. Their robotic artificiality gets a naturalist reckoning. The animated feature builds a thesis of terrestrial wonder which swiftly contrasts its central theme of kids getting addicted to screens. The attention is pitted largely on Jessie (Joan Cusack), who is worried when her owner Bonnie's parents get her an interactive tablet, Lilypad (Greta Lee), to help her make friends. Due to mounting peer pressure, Bonnie refuses to play with Jessie, who then along with her bouncy companion Bulleye, get mistakenly transported to the house of Jessie's previous owner, Emily. The film is a timely moral tale but it doesn't restrict itself only to highlight the grievances of technological anxiety. The makers define the notion of 'play' with stirring imagination. In a scene, Jessie goes on to demonstrate to some gadgets what 'real play' is when the

new kid Blaze cooks up a story with a bunch of toys, who come alive in its telling. The sequence synthesises into a reminder about the marvel of creativity and its ability to make joy palpable. Similar to the sweeping theme across the franchise, Toy Story 5 withholds the importance of toys in shaping the life of kids and even breathes fresh life into some of the memorable characters, adding a sense of age to their being. Like how Woody getting a paunch and part of his bald head reflecting light on others' faces becomes a recurring joke. The oldie cowboy sprawls up his nostalgic charm, especially in the profusely comforting voice of Tom Hanks. His lively banters with the original Buzz (Tim Allen) remain the film's highlight. The fifth part, however, belongs to Jessie, voiced with a touch of her quintessential wit and glaring empathy by Joan Cusack. Jessie's thoughtful reckoning fuels the film with a humanistic zeal, something that is

drifting away quickly in a rampantly digitised world, making the film to be the only one in the franchise to have direct parallels with the dystopian reality of our times. It is only fitting that the new Toy Story sets out to speak to the emerging attention-deficit generation in a language it has lovingly developed over the years. Through an adventure with goofy characters, it shows how joy can be lost and how it may be preserved: by reconnecting with the wild, rekindling friendships, soaring on tire swings beneath the trees, and surrendering to imagination. In its most rudimentary form, it reiterates that seeking beauty is paramount, trusting creativity is rewarding, and the vibrant hues of mischief and tomfoolery should never go extinct.

Toy Story 5 is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Timothée Chalamet and Selena Gomez to lead voice cast of Not Alone

Universal and Illumination have officially unveiled *Not Alone*, a new animated feature set for release on April 16, 2027, with Timothée Chalamet and Selena Gomez leading the voice cast. The announcement was made during the Anney International Animation Film Festival, where the studio also revealed the film's first poster. The film marks Chalamet's first leading role in a feature-length animated movie. He will voice Joe, a reserved rocket mechanic who becomes involved in a groundbreaking space mission. Gomez stars as Fran, a scientist developing an innovative rocket powered by plant-based technology.



Yash's Toxic gets new release date for August 2026 debut

After months of uncertainty and multiple postponements, *Toxic: A Fairytale for Grown-Ups* has officially locked a new theatrical release date. Actor Yash announced that the highly anticipated action drama will open in cinemas worldwide on August 26. The announcement was accompanied by a new poster from the film, featuring the tagline “Honour Thy Father,” offering fans another glimpse at the project as it moves closer to release. The film marks one of Yash's most ambitious projects since the success of the *K.G.F.* franchise. In addition to starring in the lead role, he is also the writer and producer.



Dhanush-Rajkumar Periasamy film gets a title; release date announced

The upcoming movie of Dhanush has been titled *Om - Chapter 1*. To be directed by Rajkumar Periasamy, the Tamil movie will release in two parts. The makers announced the title with a teaser. In the video, a group of woodcutters is held at gunpoint by a bunch of policemen. In the nick of time, they are saved by Dhanush's character, who is seen taking on the police officers. The action sequence takes place inside a forest during intense rain. The first part of the movie has a tagline that reads: *Udhiram: The Blood Wood* and is set to release on October 16, 2026.



A damning indictment

Built around the real emergency calls of six-year-old Hind Rajab, Ben Hania's devastating docudrama preserves a record of atrocity in excruciating detail

Arabic

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Perhaps the greatest compliment one can pay *The Voice of Hind Rajab* is that the CBFC briefly entertained the horrifying possibility that audiences might accidentally learn something from the film. Kaouther Ben Hania's Venice-winning docudrama reconstructs the final hours of Hind Rajab, the six-year-old Palestinian girl who spent January 29, 2024, trapped inside a car in Gaza City's Tel al-Hawa neighbourhood after Israeli fire killed six members of her family. For hours, she remained on the phone with Palestine Red Crescent dispatchers, surrounded by the bodies of her relatives, before she and the two paramedics sent to reach her were brutally killed by Israeli fire. Faced with this, our national custodians of public morality allegedly concluded that its release would “break up the India-Israel relationship”, which is a fascinating standard to apply, considering the film's first and only offence appears to be documenting reality. Contrary to the growing chorus of Islamophobic trolls and assorted connoisseurs of genocide denial dismissing the film as Arab agitprop online, perhaps 355 bullets fired into a six-year-old proved a little too irrefutable for even one especially prolific purveyor of cinematic slopaganда (and fellow CBFC board member) to bury beneath another avalanche of bigoted WhatsApp-university revisionism. Ben Hania, the Tunisian filmmaker whose previous features *The Man Who Sold His Skin* and *Four Daughters* both secured Academy Award nominations, approaches this material through an austere formal framework. Rather than reconstructing the attack itself, she confines almost the entire film to the Palestine Red Crescent emergency call

The Voice of Hind Rajab

Director: Kaouther Ben Hania

Cast: Motaz Malhees, Saja Kilani, Amer Hlehel, Clara Khoury

Storyline: Volunteers at the Palestine Red Crescent Society stay on the phone with a 6-year-old girl who gets trapped in a car in war-torn Gaza

centre in Ramallah, a city in the occupied West Bank located roughly fifty miles from where Hind was trapped. Motaz Malhees plays dispatcher Omar Alqam, the real operator who spent hours speaking with Hind, while Saja Kilani, Amer Hlehel and Clara Khoury portray the colleagues attempting to organise a rescue mission through a labyrinth of military approvals and communications bottlenecks. The film maps the excruciating administrative machinery governing survival in Gaza, explaining how the Palestine Red Crescent could not simply dispatch the nearest ambulance to a terrified child trapped less than ten minutes away, but instead had to navigate a chain of approvals involving the Palestinian Ministry of Health, the International Committee of the Red Cross and the IDF, before a vehicle could legally enter the area. The otherwise eight-minute rescue gradually metastasises into an hours-long exercise in procedural paralysis, with the dispatchers trapped in the crippling position of begging the same military apparatus that shredded Hind's family car for permission to rescue its sole surviving occupant. The terrified voice we hear throughout the film belongs to Hind herself. The emergency recordings are real, preserved from the calls she made while trapped among the bodies of her relatives. Every time she speaks, we are reminded that there is no screenwriter imagining these words and no actor performing them. And Ben Hania further collapses the boundary between reconstruction and testimony by incorporating footage of the actual Red Crescent personnel involved in the rescue effort. The docufiction hybrid effect is difficult to shake because it denies all comforts of reminding ourselves that this is only a movie. There is, admittedly, a reckless (and disconcerting) kind of brilliance in what Ben Hania is doing here that will undoubtedly raise eyebrows. Is it exploitative to build a feature around the final hours of a murdered child? Is it in bad taste to dramatically reconstruct one

of the most horrifying audio recordings to emerge from the genocide in Gaza? Perhaps. It isn't difficult to understand why those questions are worth asking. But far too much time and effort has been spent on filmmakers congratulating themselves for telling us stories about fictional suffering and fictional injustice to recognise the rarity of somebody forcing us to confront one of the most defining atrocities of our time. I remain instinctively sceptical whenever filmmakers venture this close to capturing real-world suffering, because the distance between art and exploitation has now become more alarmingly porous than most artists care to admit. Yet the equally uncomfortable truth is that the internet generation has been subjected to such a relentless conveyor belt of algorithmically curated atrocity that only the most extraordinary horrors still possess the power to puncture the numbness. No sane person should ever become comfortable hearing a frightened little girl trapped among the bodies of her family, and Ben Hania makes sure of that. That tension is what makes *The Voice of Hind Rajab* such a ruthlessly effective piece of filmmaking. As of yesterday, the commander of the 52nd Battalion of Israel's 401st Armored Brigade, the same battalion repeatedly linked by investigators to Hind's killing, was himself killed during operations in southern. I would be lying if I said the image of one more participant in this sickening machinery of slaughter being EKIA'd did not provide some indulgent sense of satisfaction. But nothing can quite compensate for the fact that one of the most comprehensively documented atrocities of the twenty-first century has been systematically trivialised, endlessly what-abouted, denied in plain sight and even enthusiastically justified whenever denial became untenable. May the very existence of *The Voice of Hind Rajab* preserve for posterity this grotesque abdication of human conscience.

The Voice of Hind Rajab is currently running in theatres